Completion problems

Bridging modelling and independence

Use completion problems to bridge a full worked example and an independent solution. Keep part of the successful structure visible while students supply the missing decisions.

How to do it well

1 Model the full example. Complete the method from start to finish and explain the purpose of each important decision.

2 Fade the final step. Leave only the ending incomplete and ask pupils to finish it while the earlier structure remains visible.

3 Prompt the principle. Ask pupils to explain the rule, relationship or criterion that makes their completion valid.

4 Increase the blanks. Remove more of the example so pupils complete progressively larger and earlier sections.

5 Release a similar task. Pupils plan and complete a closely matched example without the support, then check against the success criteria.

What this sounds like

“The first three steps are complete. Finish the conclusion and explain how the evidence above supports it. On the next example, you will supply the final two steps.”

Classroom example. A Maths completion task supplies the setup and first lines but leaves the final decision blank. Pupils finish and explain the rule they used. The next task removes the final two stages while keeping the demand comparable. A clean independent question follows, checking whether pupils can organise the method without the visible structure.

Top tips that make the technique work

Start with the final step. Backward fading keeps the earlier structure available while students finish the process.

Keep demand comparable. Do not remove support and introduce a new representation or harder content in the same move.

Make the blank meaningful. A missing decision reveals more than an obvious word copied from the line above.

Ask for the principle. Students should explain why their completion fits the method or criterion.

Finish with a clean attempt. A complete independent example checks whether the visible structure was doing too much of the work.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Increase responsibility in manageable stages.	Removing random lines without a rationale.
Keep the underlying task stable while fading.	Filling blanks that require no meaningful decision.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

DistillED - Fading Support | Barton - We Do